

Gender in Simte

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Abstract

Simte is one of the Kuki-Chin languages spoken mostly in Churachandpur and Pherzawl districts of Manipur. The language falls under the North Kuki-Chin sub-groups of the Kuki-Chin language family (Lewis. et.al, 2013). This paper attempts to describe the gender markers in Simte. The gender markers for [+human] are ‘*pa*’ for masculine and ‘*nu*’ for feminine gender. Whereas the gender markers for [-human, + animal] are ‘*tal*’ for masculine and ‘*nu*’ for feminine. The neuter gender can be identified by their own lexical term such as ‘*naupan*’ for a child. It is observed that the morphemes ‘*pu*’ and ‘*pi*’ have multiple functions. First, ‘*pu*’ serves as a gender marker for both the maternal grandfather and paternal grandfather while ‘*pi*’ functions as a gender marker for both the maternal grandmother and paternal grandmother. Second, they are used as honorific terms showing respect to elders. Third, they are used to categorized male and female genders in authority or persons highly regarded in the society.

Keywords: Simte, Kuki-Chin, North east India, gender markers, neuter gender.

1. Introduction

Simte is one of the Kuki-Chin language family inhabiting in the North-Eastern part of India. They are predominantly concentrated in Churachandpur and Pherzawl districts of Manipur (Hangluah, 2019). According to Singh and Suantak (2011), scores of Simte population are scattered in Sikkim, Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Mizoram, Meghalaya, Tripura and Assam. According to 2011 Census, this tribe constitutes a total population of 6,728.

Language endangerment is evident in this case, as intergenerational transmission is largely restricted to specific social domains, such as familial and religious (e.g., church) settings. Although the language is incorporated into the educational system as a medium of instruction up to Class X under the Board of Secondary Education, Manipur, its visibility remains limited due to the absence of promotion through print media. This lack of broader institutional and media support raises concerns about the language's long-term vitality and sustainability.

Mention may also be made that the tribe is also recognized as one of the Scheduled Tribes by the Government of India in 1956. It is officially recorded in the Government of India Tribe Recognition Order of 1956 vide S.R.O, 24774 Gazette of India, Part II, Section III, No. 316A, New Delhi, 29th October, 1956 (Ching, 2012).

Chelliah (2015) agrees with Haokip (2011, pp.60) argument on multiple languages prevalent in Manipur. She further states that Manipur hosts more than 29 languages, and bilingualism and code-switching are prominent especially within the Kuki-Chin languages. It also results in the convergence of languages with fewer speakers being subsumed by structurally and similar languages which have political and economic prestige. Due to code-switching and code-mixing, Haokip (2011) is also of the opinion that some of the young Gangte speakers are shifting to Thadou and young Simte speakers shifting towards Paite.

2. Methodology

The present study has been carried out by conducting a field work in Pamjal Village and Joutung village of Pherzawl district of Manipur. More than 10 informants, aged between 45-55 were interviewed, and the data were also cross-examined with different age groups of the same community. Journals, books and e-materials were also accessed for the secondary data.

3. Literature Review

According to Corbett (1991:1), the term 'gender' has its origins in the Latin word 'genus' and was passed down through Old French as 'gendre'. The original interpretation of the term is rendered as 'kind' or 'sort'. The term 'gender' is employed to refer to both a collection of nouns and the entire category. Thus, a particular language encompasses three genders: masculine, feminine, and neuter. Lyons (1968:283) argues that the three genders of Greek and Latin, namely masculine, feminine, and neuter, were the primary noun categories acknowledged in their respective grammars. The classical Indo-European languages classify gender into three categories: masculine, feminine, and neutral.

Grierson (1904) describes the gender markers of some of the Kuki-Chin languages such as Thadou, Paite and Lushai (Mizo). These languages have distinct markers for both the masculine gender and feminine gender. They employ 'pa' for masculine human gender and 'nu' for feminine human gender. However, there is distinction in the gender markers for non-human among these Kuki-Chin groups. Thadou, Vaiphei and Gangte exhibit 'cal' for masculine and 'pi' for feminine gender. Languages such as Zou, Paite, Simte and Teddim Chin exhibit 'tal' gender marker for non-human masculine gender while 'pi' is employed for feminine gender. (Haokip, 2009; Haokip, 2014; Singh, 2009; Cing, 2017). The similar gender distinction is attested by Kuki-Chin languages such as Hmar (Bapuia & Baruah, 1996), Zou, Gangte, Vaiphei, Simte (Haokip, 2009) and Teddim Chin (Cing, 2017). In the existing literature of Simte languages, gender markers were discussed in parts by Naorem Brojen Singh in his unpublished thesis '*Simte Grammar*' in 2009. The gender markers are

also discussed in Connie Champeon book '*Simte Writers' Handbook*' in 2019. The above studies were carried out by etic researchers who highlight the morphemes for gender distinction. The present study is emic research who not only highlights the morphemes for the gender distinction but also attempts to describe the functions of these gender markers.

4. Gender in Simte

Like other Kuki-Chin languages, Simte does not exhibit any grammatical gender but gender is determined based on meaning (cf. Haokip, 2009). In Simte, the gender markers for human beings and animals are different. Essentially, the lexical meaning of '*pa*' means 'father' and '*nu*' means 'mother'. Generally, both these morphemes can be used as an identification of gender thus serve as a gender marker.

4.1 Gender markers for animate [+human]

The gender markers for human beings are '*-pa*' and '*-nu*'. '*-pa*' is the masculine marker while '*-nu*' is the feminine marker. Both of these markers are suffixed to the noun. The gender markers for human beings are illustrated in the following examples.

1(a). *puan sɔp -pa hun tuŋ -ta*
cloth wash M COP arrive PFV
'The washer man has arrived'

1(b). *puan sɔp -nu hung tuŋ -ta*
cloth wash F COP arrive PFV
'The washer woman has arrived'

2(a) *inveŋ -pa toʔ bazar ka -hoʔ -uʔ*
neighbour M and bazaar ISG go PL
'I and my male neighbour go to the market'

2(b). *inveŋ -nu toʔ bazar ka -hoʔ -uʔ*
neighbour F and bazaar ISG go PL
'I and my female neighbour go to the market'

4.2 Gender markers for animate [-human]

For gender reference of animals, '*-tal*' is suffixed to the noun to indicate the masculine gender and '*-pi*' is suffixed to the noun to indicate the feminine gender. The argument is exemplified from 3(a)-4(b).

3(a). ui **-tal** -in mi k^hat a- pet

dog M ERG person one 3SG bite

'The male dog (stud) bite one person'

3(b). ui **-pi** -in nou a -nei -ta

dog F ERG baby 3SG own PFV

'The female dog (bitch) has delivered a baby'

4(a). a? **-tal** k^huay -in ka- t^hou zou -ta

chicken M crook ADV 1SG awake finish PFV

'I was already awake when the rooster crowed'

4(b). a? **-pi** -in banj^hi cia? tu:i a- tha diai

chicken F ERG when time egg 3SG lay Q

'When will the hen lay eggs?'

a. Functions of the gender markers '-pu' and '-pi'

The gender markers-*pu* and *-pi* are used in kinship terms such as grandfather and grandmother respectively. Besides, they occur before the referent nouns. This is illustrated in examples 5(a) to 5(d).

5 (a.) ka **-pu** kum 80 ahi

1SG grandfather year 80 DECL

'My grandfather is 80 years old'

5 (b) ka **-pi** a- upat vajin a- dam thei hi

1SG grand-mother 3SG old although 3SG well possible COP

'Although my grand-mother is of age, she is still healthy'

5(c) ka **-pu** lian -in a- huŋ panpi?

1SG grand-father lian ERG 3SG COP help

'My grand-father lian helped me'

5(d) **pi** luni a dam -lou

Grand-mother luni 3SG well NEG

'Grand-mother Luni is sick'

Both these gender markers function as honorific terms signifying respect to the elders. They are suffixed to the referent noun as exemplified in 6(a) and 6 (b).

6(a.) *hausa -pu -in k^hosuj su? -sianj ding a- fɪ*

chief- M- ERG village CAUS clean COP 3SG say

'The male chief instructs the villagers to clean the village'.

6(b) *hausa -pu siʔzou in hausa -pi -in khua a- enkol*

chief -M die SEQ chief - F - ERG village 3SG look after

'After the male chief died, his wife is taking charge of the village'.

Interestingly, the gender markers *'-pu'* and *'-pi'* are also used to refer to persons who have authority or person with high social status. Structurally, the two gender markers are suffixed to the referent NP. Examples 7(a) and 7 (b) are illustrative.

7(a) *lamkai -pu -in nasem -te toʔguan a- pia*

leader M ERG worker PL job 3SG give

'The male leader is giving a job to their workers'.

7(b) *lamkai -pi -in nupi tej nataj a- kuan dijin a -fɪal*

leader F ERG women all social work 3SG go PURP 3SG invite

'The woman leader invites all the womenfolk to participate in the social work'

4.4 Neuter or common gender in Simte

Simte also exhibits a neuter or common gender, where the gender is indicated by the presence of the lexical noun. This The neuter gender is exemplified in (8-10)

(8). *naupanj a- fɪaʔ -na diŋ lampi diʔ a -fɪl a- hoiʔ*

child 3SG go NMZ UNR ASP way right 3SG train 3SG good

'It is good to train up the child in the right path'

(9). *gari -in kel a -phu -lum*

vehicle ERG goat 3SG hit sleep

'A vehicle knock down/ kill a goat'.

(10) *vapal in aʔ ka k^hoi -ut*

pigeon house LOC 1SG rear want

'I want to rear pigeons at home'.

There are certain animate (human) beings where the gender markers are not attached to it. But it is innately understood by the native speaker that the lexical noun itself carries the gender specifics. It is explained in the following column.

Table 1: Gender specifics intrinsic in the lexical items

<i>ni</i>	<i>Father's sister Or, grandfather sister</i>	<i>gaŋ</i>	<i>Father sister's husband or grandfather sister's husband</i>
<i>zi</i>	<i>Wife</i>	<i>pasal</i>	<i>Husband</i>
<i>nuŋa:ʔ</i>	<i>Female youth/ girl</i>	<i>taŋval</i>	<i>Male youth/ boy</i>
<i>meigoŋ</i>	<i>Widow</i>	<i>pagoŋ</i>	<i>Widower</i>
<i>pasal</i>	<i>Male</i>	<i>numei</i>	<i>Female</i>

In a rare case, the gender of a person is highlighted twice by the presence of gender specifics intrinsic in a lexical noun and the morphological gender suffixes. In examples 11-12 the gender specific lexical nouns occur along with the gender suffixes. This is because the focus or attention of the discourse is on the referent subject NP. Whereas in examples 13 and 14, the bone of contention is that someone is narrating an incident without necessarily focusing on a particular person or thing. Hence, the absence of the focus provides room for the omission of the gender suffixes.

(11) *pasal* *naupaŋ* *-pa* *komaʔ* *na* *leʔkhathon* *ka-* *pia*
male child M to 2SG letter 1SG give
'I give your letter to the boy child'

(12). *numei* *naupaŋ* *-nu* *komaʔ* *na* *leʔkhathon* *ka-* *pia*
female child F to 2SG letter 1SG give
'I give your letter to the girl child'.

(13). *ka-* *nu* *dam* *-lou* *ifu* *ka* *nitoʔ* *ka* *gaŋ* *-in* *a* *huŋveʔ* *-uʔ*
1SG mother well NEG DEF 1SG aunt and 1SG uncle ERG 3SG COP visit PL
'My uncle and aunt came to visit my sick mother'

(14). *nuŋa:ʔ* *-te* *-n* *misi* *in* *aʔ* *sinpi* *a-* *hom* *-uʔ*
girl PL ERG dead house LOC tea 3SG serve PL
'The girls were serving tea at the funeral house'

4.5 Word formation processes of gendered nouns in Simte

The word formation processes for gendered nouns in Simte primarily involve affixation, compounding, and occasionally reduplication, though gender marking is not as extensive as in Indo-European languages. Here's a breakdown of the key processes:

4.5.1 Affixation (Prefixation/Suffixation)

Simte uses gender-specific affixes to distinguish male and female referents, particularly in kinship terms, occupations, or natural gender distinctions.

(15) (a) **pa-** *t^han*
M *thang*
 'Uncle Thang'

(15) (b) **nu-** *lun*
F *lun*
 'Aunt Lun'

(15) (c) *annhuan* **-pa**
cook *M*
 'Male Cook'

(15) (d) *innp^hiat* **-nu**
sweeper *F*
 'Female sweeper'

4.5.2 Compounding

Gendered nouns in Simte are formed by combining a neutral root with a gender-specific morpheme or word. It is illustrated in the following examples.

(16) *naupan* + **pa**
child *M*
 'Male Child'

(17) *houtu* + **nu**
teacher *F*
 'Female teacher'

4.5.3 Reduplication

Reduplication in Kuki-Chin languages is more frequent for plurality, intensification, or ideophones rather than gender marking. It is somehow found in Hmar, but not in Simte. In Hmar, the reduplicated form *tu-tu* refers to "small male child!" while *nu-nu* refers to "small female child," or an "affectionate child". Simte does not exhibit such construction to identify the gendered nouns.

5. Conclusion

In Simte, the lexical items are extensively used to accentuate the distinction of the genders. The lexical items such as ‘*pa*’ and ‘*nu*’ have multiple functions. It serves as a gender marker for both the masculine and feminine human class of gender. It is also observed that the lexical items such as ‘*pu*’ and ‘*pi*’ are employed to address the person of high authority or used as honorific titles. These gender markers are suffixed to the referent NP. In matter concerning the common or neuter gender, the referent lexical noun carries the gender specifics. To emphasize the referent NP, the gender specific lexical nouns are followed by the morphemes ‘*pa*’ and ‘*nu*’.

Abbreviations

1SG	First Person Singular
2SG	Second Person Singular
3SG	Third Person Singular
ADV	Adverb(ial)
COP	Copula
DECL	Declarative
DEF	Definite marker
ERG	Ergative
F	Feminine
LOC	Locative
M	Masculine
NEG	Negation
NMZ	Nominalizer
PFV	Perfective
PL	Plural
PURP	Purposive Marker
Q	Question Marker
SEQ	Sequential
UNR.	ASP Unrealized Aspect

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